

Missed, Ignored and Delayed

The third week of April is dedicated to increasing awareness about Parkinson's Disease, a rare brain disorder

DOPAMINE DROUGHT

With the world marking Parkinson's Day on April 11, the disease that afflicts about 1 per cent of the world population over the age of 65 has come under the scanner. Parkinson's Disease (PD) occurs when certain nerves in the brain die, hampering the supply of dopamine, a chemical responsible for communication among brain cells. A degeneration of the nervous system takes place, affecting a person's muscle co-ordination—tremors, rigidity, slow movement, depression, changes in sleep, eating and sleeping patterns. A complex disorder, it is significantly under-diagnosed in India.

70-90

PER 1,00,000 INDIANS ARE ESTIMATED TO SUFFER FROM PARKINSON'S DISEASE

TELL-TALE SYMPTOMS

Early signs of Parkinson's are often subtle and go unnoticed for months and years. Symptoms typically begin on one side of the body and usually remain worse on that side.



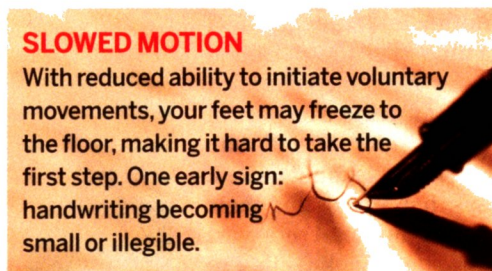
TREMOR

The characteristic shaking associated with PD often begins in a hand: a back-and-forth rubbing of the thumb and fore-finger, known as pill-rolling. Or it may be shaking in one limb, especially when at rest.



RIGID MUSCLES

Reduced facial expression, stiffness in the limbs and neck. Stiffness can get so severe that it may limit the range of movements and cause pain.



SLOWED MOTION

With reduced ability to initiate voluntary movements, your feet may freeze to the floor, making it hard to take the first step. One early sign: handwriting becoming small or illegible.



LOSS OF AUTOMATIC MOVEMENTS

Unconscious acts such as blinking, smiling tend to be diminished. Other signs? Reduced swinging of one hand while walking, a fixed stare or animated gestures while speaking.

SPEECH CHANGES

May become too soft, too rapid or monotonous; sometimes slurring or repeating words, or hesitating before speaking.



An Ibuprofen a day?



An ongoing study at the Harvard School of Public Health, US, finds

those who take ibuprofen regularly—the common drug for mild pain, fever and inflammation—are 40 per cent less prone to PD. Reason? Brain inflammation causes PD and ibuprofen helps in countering the same. The study is not conclusive but the prognosis is promising.



DOUBLE WHAMMY

India is among the countries where the incidence of Parkinson's Disease is expected to double in the next generation, says a study published in *Neurology*. While the number of people with the disease is slated to double in the US to six lakh, the greatest growth is estimated to occur in developing countries in Asia.

CURCUMIN CURE

Researchers at IIT-Allahabad and NIMHANS, Bangalore, have designed a chemical from the Indian kitchen staple, turmeric, that they claim can fight PD. Turmeric contains curcumin known for its anti-oxidant properties. In PD, it can contain the 'free radicals' that damage brain cells producing dopamine.



■ Compiled by **Damayanti Datta**